

- RAG Learning

2.9 Nationalism

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 2: Non-core Political Ideas, Section B

Exam Tip: This is one of **five** non-core ideas. You sit **one** of Anarchism, Ecologism, Feminism, Multiculturalism or Nationalism, answering a single 24-mark "To what extent" question (AO1 8 / AO2 8 / AO3 8). Learn your chosen idea properly rather than all five thinly.

Nationalism holds that humanity divides naturally into nations, and that nations are entitled to govern themselves. It has been the most politically consequential idea of the modern era — and the most double-edged, because the same premise underwrote liberation from empire and the subordination of minorities within the states that liberation created.

Nation — a community bound by shared culture, history, language or identity, which may or may not have its own state.

State — a political and legal entity with defined territory, a permanent population, a government and sovereignty.

Nation-state — a state whose borders coincide with a national community.

Self-determination — the principle that a nation has the right to govern itself.

Civic nationalism — the nation defined by shared political values, institutions and citizenship.

Ethnic nationalism — the nation defined by common descent, culture and ancestry.

Cultural nationalism — emphasis on preserving a nation's language and customs, not necessarily on statehood.

Volksgeist — Herder's term for the distinctive spirit of a people, expressed in language and custom.

Integral nationalism — an authoritarian, organic conception in which the individual is wholly subordinate to the nation.

Chauvinism — belief in the superiority of one's own nation over others.

Imagined community — Anderson's description of the nation as a community members imagine, since they will never meet most of it.

1. Core ideas and principles

Principle	What it means
The nation	Humanity divides into nations, which are the proper units of political community
Self-determination	Nations are entitled to govern themselves; borders should follow national communities
Culturalism	National culture — language, custom, history — is valuable and should be preserved
Racialism	In some strands, the nation is defined biologically. Rejected by civic and liberal nationalists
Internationalism	Liberal nationalists hold that free nations co-operate; expansionists reject this

Nation and state distinguished

A nation is a sociological and psychological entity; a state is a legal and political one. They frequently do not coincide: the Kurds are a nation without a state; the UK is a state containing several nations; many post-colonial states contain multiple nations within borders drawn by others. Nationalism is the doctrine that the two *should* coincide — which is why it has been the most destabilising principle in modern politics.

2. Types of nationalism

Type	Basis	Politics	Example
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Liberal	Self-determination as a universal right belonging equally to all nations	Constitutional government, international co-operation	Mazzini's Italy; Woodrow Wilson's Fourteen Points
Conservative	The nation as a source of continuity, tradition and social cohesion	Defensive, sceptical of rapid change and of supranational bodies	Much mainstream European nationalism
Anti-colonial	National liberation from imperial rule, often fused with socialism	Independence, control of resources, development	Twentieth-century decolonisation; Garvey's pan-Africanism
Expansionist / integral	National superiority; the individual subordinate to the nation	Authoritarian, militaristic, chauvinist	Maurras's <i>Action Française</i>

Civic and ethnic

	Civic	Ethnic
Membership	Shared values, institutions, citizenship — open in principle to anyone	Common descent, culture, ancestry — inherited, not chosen
Compatible with diversity?	Yes, in principle	No — exclusive by construction
Caution	The distinction is a spectrum, not a clean division: civic nations still operate in particular languages and teach particular histories, and civic nationalisms have hardened into ethnic ones under pressure	

3. Key thinkers

Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1712–78) — *The Social Contract* (1762). The **general will**: sovereignty belongs to the people as a collective body with a common interest, distinct from the sum of private wills. He gave nationalism its foundation of **popular sovereignty** — the idea that legitimate authority flows from the people rather than from a monarch or dynasty. He is not himself straightforwardly a nationalist, but no nationalism is possible without his premise.

Johann Gottfried Herder (1744–1803) — **cultural nationalism**. Each nation possesses a distinctive **Volksgeist**, a spirit expressed through its language, customs, folklore and history, which should be cherished and preserved. His nationalism is pluralist rather than hierarchical: every culture has its own value, and none is superior. It does not necessarily demand a state — the objective is the flourishing of the culture.

Giuseppe Mazzini (1805–72) — **liberal nationalism**. Nations should achieve unification and independence and then co-operate as free equals; a Europe of free nations would be a peaceful one. Nationhood carries duties as well as rights — to one's own nation and, through it, to humanity. Central to Italian unification, and the clearest case of nationalism as a liberating rather than an oppressive force.

Marcus Garvey (1887–1940) — **black nationalism and pan-Africanism**. Liberation requires racial pride, economic self-reliance and a common political project among people of African descent, including the possibility of return to Africa. Founded the Universal Negro Improvement Association and the Black Star Line. Significant because he extends national self-determination to a people dispersed by slavery rather than occupying a single territory, and because psychological liberation — pride, recovered history — is treated as a precondition of political liberation.

Charles Maurras (1868–1952) — **integral nationalism**. The nation is an organic whole to which the individual is wholly subordinate; its interests override individual rights entirely. Anti-democratic, monarchist and authoritarian, associated with *Action Française*. He is on

the specification precisely to show nationalism's dark side: the same premise that liberated Italy underwrites the subordination of the individual to the nation.

Exam Tip: The five thinkers are chosen to span the range — Rousseau supplies the foundation, Herder the cultural version, Mazzini the liberal, Garvey the anti-colonial, Maurras the authoritarian. A 24-mark answer should use that spread as evidence: the fact that one doctrine accommodates Mazzini *and* Maurras is the strongest single point about nationalism's nature.

4. Nationalism on the nation, human nature, society and the state

	Position	Internal disagreement
The nation	The primary source of political identity and loyalty	Defined by culture and descent, or by shared institutions and citizenship
Human nature	People need belonging and identity; the nation supplies both	Whether national identity is natural and primordial, or modern and constructed
Society	Organic and bound by shared culture and history	Whether a society can be multinational, or must be culturally unified
The state	Should correspond to the nation — the nation-state ideal	Whether statehood is required at all (cultural nationalism) or essential

Are nations natural or constructed?

Primordialists hold that national identities are ancient and organic, with demonstrable continuity of language and custom over long periods. **Modernists** — Anderson's "imagined communities", Gellner, Hobsbawm's "invented traditions" — hold that nations are products of modernity: print capitalism, standardised national languages, mass education and newspapers allowed large populations to conceive of themselves as a single community moving through history together.

Anderson's point is not that nations are false. Members will never meet most fellow nationals, so belonging must be imagined — as it must in any community beyond the face-to-face. An imagined community commands genuine loyalty and sacrifice, and its political effects are entirely real. The analysis explains nationalism's force rather than dismissing it, and it undercuts only the nationalist's own claim that the nation is primordial.

5. Evaluation

Is nationalism a coherent ideology?

No	Yes
Has underwritten liberal republicanism, anti-colonial socialism and fascism alike	A consistent core: humanity divides into nations; national identity is a primary loyalty; nations should govern themselves
No canonical text, no agreed account of human nature, no theory of how the economy or society should be organised	Those are substantive claims, denied by liberals (the individual is primary), socialists (class is primary) and cosmopolitans (borders carry no moral weight)
Supplies no criterion for identifying which groups <i>are</i> nations — the one question it exists to answer	It answers a different question from other ideologies: what the political community <i>is</i> , not how it should be organised

The judgement: nationalism is coherent as a claim about the *unit* of politics and incoherent as a *programme*, and the second follows from the first. Like ecologism, it is cross-cutting rather than free-standing: it supplies premises that must fuse with a social analysis before they generate policy. Measuring it against liberalism or socialism is measuring it against ideologies answering a different question.

Why the consequences have been so varied

The deepest point, and the best way to end an essay: nationalism supplies no principle for determining which groups count as nations entitled to self-government, so **every nationalism**

must at some point deny to others the claim it makes for itself. Anti-colonial movements invoked self-determination against empire; the states they created then faced the identical claim from minorities within their borders. That is not a contingent failing but a structural feature — which is why nationalism has been both the most liberating and the most destructive political force of the modern era, frequently in the same place within a generation.

Quick recall

- Core: the nation, self-determination, culturalism, racialism (some strands), internationalism (liberal strands)
- Nation ≠ state; nationalism says they should coincide
- Types: liberal, conservative, anti-colonial, expansionist/integral
- Civic (institutions, open) against ethnic (descent, closed) — a spectrum, not a clean line
- Rousseau: the general will, popular sovereignty — the foundation
- Herder: Volksgeist; cultural nationalism; pluralist, not hierarchical
- Mazzini: liberal nationalism; free nations co-operating
- Garvey: pan-Africanism; psychological liberation precedes political
- Maurras: integral nationalism; the individual wholly subordinate
- Anderson: imagined communities — explains nationalism's force, does not dismiss it
- Every nationalism must deny to others the claim it makes for itself